

People of Color

by Sophia



WHAT'S COVERED

In this lesson, you will learn about the differences that have to do with ancestry and culture, including physical characteristics, language, and religion. Specifically, this lesson will cover:

1. Race and Ethnicity



Historically and currently, many different populations have been discriminated against in business settings on the basis of race and ethnicity. But before we take on this topic, we need to clarify what these terms mean, and how they differ.

Race is a socially constructed category that produces real effects on the people who are racialized. It refers to physical differences that a particular society considers significant, such as skin color and hair styles. **Ethnicity** describes shared culture: the practices, values, and beliefs of a group. This culture might include shared language, religion, and traditions, among other commonalities, and is often based on country or region of origin.

➔ **EXAMPLE** A dark-skinned person whose parents immigrated from the Dominican Republic might be considered to be in the racial category of Black and the ethnicity category of Hispanic. A light-skinned person whose parents immigrated from Argentina might be considered to be in the racial category of White, and the ethnicity category of Hispanic. These two people might have some common characteristics based on their shared Hispanic ethnicity, but their experiences of the U.S. business landscape would likely diverge on the basis of race.

Throughout the history of U.S. business, the greatest share of power and ownership in businesses has been held by people who are both European American (the racial group known as White) and Christian. Since the 1960s, the term “**people of color**” has been used to describe the variety of people who do not share that

background.



HINT

In addition to people of color (or POC for short), you might also encounter references to **BIPOC**. This is an acronym for Black, Indigenous, and people of color, which is sometimes used to reflect the distinct histories of Black and Indigenous people in the United States.

In addition, the challenges faced by a person of color are exacerbated when they belong to other marginalized groups. For example, Black women are typically paid less than both White women and Black men. Hispanic immigrants face more discrimination than European immigrants, and Native Americans with disabilities face more barriers than White people with disabilities.

Even in well-meaning workplaces, people of marginalized backgrounds can face minor mistreatments and misunderstandings, termed **microaggressions**; these are indirect, subtle, and even unintentional reminders of someone's marginalized status. For example, describing a Black colleague as "articulate," while a compliment, implies that it is surprising or notable that they would be clear spoken. Describing oneself as "color blind" can be seen as denying other people's lived experiences. Microaggressions can make people of color feel marginalized, which in turn leads to low engagement, and low engagement to less recognition or promotion, so even small asides and jokes that seem harmless contribute to the bigger problem. For example, imagine the only person of color in a department hearing coworkers complaining about "woke" policies. They would likely feel their contributions aren't appreciated.

The standards of business culture can also be discriminatory, such as norms for hair in the conception of "professional appearance" excluding natural hair for people of African descent. This particularly affects Black women, who feel pressured to straighten their hair or keep their hair very short. For this reason, there are now laws introduced in some jurisdictions specifically naming hairstyle as protected against discrimination.



TERMS TO KNOW

Race

A socially constructed category that produces real effects on the people who are racialized. It refers to physical differences that a particular society considers significant, such as skin color.

Ethnicity

Shared culture; the practices, values, and beliefs of a group. This culture might include shared language, religion, and traditions, among other commonalities, and is often based on country or region of origin.

People of Color

People who are not considered to be White by the current American social structure.

Microaggressions

Indirect, subtle, and even unintentional reminders of someone's marginalized status.

BIPOC

Acronym for Black, Indigenous, and people of color. Used to acknowledge the historical differences between Black and Indigenous people and other groups. (Pronounced "bye-pock.")

2. Religious Differences

According to the Pew Research Center, 30% of Americans are affiliated with minority religions or profess no

religion at all. But the dominant business culture in America has historically been Christian, and especially Protestant. People of other religions have faced both active and passive discrimination in the workforce, from professional organizations that have historically excluded Jews or Catholics from membership, to the common situation where businesses are closed on Christmas, but someone of a minority religion would have to request time off for their own holidays. Note that religion often overlaps substantially with ethnicity.



LEARN MORE

See the complete data on religious identity at www.pewresearch.org/religion/religious-landscape-study/. Separate from situations of bigotry and discrimination, religious diversity in the workplace can also cause challenges for well-meaning employers and managers when the practices of specific religious traditions are mutually exclusive. For example, Muslims have religious observation on Fridays, which is not part of the traditional weekend in the West. While religion-neutral terms like “winter holiday” replace “Christmas vacation” at secular organizations, they still land where they favor most Christians (excluding Orthodox Christians), and such extended breaks are usually not offered for other faiths. Decor also becomes controversial; while many businesses have put up Christmas trees in December (and some still do), others might shy away from the practice because it is a reminder to religious minorities that they are marginalized. At the same time, Christians often get upset by changing traditions at work.



THINK ABOUT IT

How can a business culture acknowledge and accommodate religious diversity without excluding or inconveniencing anyone?

3. National Origin

National origin and immigration status are closely connected to ethnicity, but they are distinct categories because of different perceptions of and experiences of people who are first- or second-generation Americans. Legally, national origin is defined as the country where one or one’s ancestors came from. Note that not all nationalities have a politically viable state, however, such as the Hmong people of East and Southeast Asia.

Some fields have large numbers of immigrants in their workforces, both in high-status professions such as software development and medicine, and in low-status jobs like hospitality and agriculture.

Discrimination and exclusion on the basis of national origin is sometimes called **nativism**. **Nativism** is the political position of preserving rights and access for certain established inhabitants of a country, as compared to claims of newcomers or immigrants. In the U.S., it might include people of color who have been in the U.S. for several generations but does not specifically refer to Indigenous people.

Nativism has greatly impacted labor and business history in the United States, from the Chinese Exclusion Act in 1882 that banned all immigration of Chinese laborers for more than fifty years, to the recent dramatic increases of immigration raids on businesses that employ many Hispanic immigrant workers due to rising anti-Hispanic nativism. However, not all forms of discrimination involve people with European ancestry; discrimination can also occur between people of different national origins with a history of animosity or discrimination. For example, in 2023, Seattle became the first jurisdiction to include caste as a protected class; this protects people of Indian ancestry from discrimination by other ethnic groups from India.



TERMS TO KNOW

National Origin

The country where one or one's ancestors come from. In some cases, national origin may be from a stateless people who have a national identity but not a politically viable state.

Nativism

The political position of preserving rights and access for certain established inhabitants of a country, as compared to claims of newcomers or immigrants.

4. Ethical Considerations

Creating an equitable and inclusive work environment is a crucial responsibility of business leaders, supervisors, and managers. This task requires them to foster an environment where all employees feel valued and respected regardless of their race, religion, or national origin (among other differences we will read about in subsequent tutorials). While the process of cultivating an equitable and inclusive work environment may appear quite challenging, managers can take positive action by implementing specific, incremental strategies such as diversity training, appropriate responses to complaints, and conflict resolution.

One size does not fit all, and what works for one employer in Atlanta may not work for an employer in Seattle, New York, Boston, or Dallas. That said, one of the most effective ways to cultivate an inclusive work environment is through diversity training. This training aims to promote awareness and understanding of different cultures, values, and beliefs, and it can help employees develop empathy and sensitivity towards colleagues from diverse backgrounds. Diversity training can also provide employees with practical strategies to recognize and address instances of discrimination or harassment in the workplace.

Again, one size does not fit all, and sometimes a well-intentioned program can do more harm than good. Diversity training can be ineffective or contribute to conflict if it is not implemented correctly. For instance, managers must ensure that the training is ongoing and not just a one-time event. They should also consider tailoring the training to the specific needs of their organization and its employees. Additionally, they should take the time to evaluate the effectiveness of the training and make necessary adjustments as needed.

Listening plays a critical role in equitable and inclusive work environments, and a critical aspect of cultivating an equitable and inclusive work environment is having appropriate responses to complaints. Managers should create a culture where employees feel comfortable reporting incidents of discrimination, harassment, or bias. They should have clear policies and procedures in place to address these complaints and ensure that they are taken seriously. Managers should also ensure that complaints are handled confidentially and that employees feel supported throughout the process. In situations where conflict arises, managers should aim to resolve the conflict in a way that is fair and respectful to all parties involved.

Conflict resolution strategies that provide specific ways to resolve issues, with examples and “I” statements, can be particularly effective. Conflict resolution strategies can include encouraging open communication, active listening, and finding mutually beneficial solutions. Managers should also avoid taking sides or dismissing employee concerns, and they should ensure that all employees have access to the same resources and support.



SUMMARY

In this lesson, you learned that creating an equitable and inclusive work environment for people of color is an ongoing process that requires a proactive approach from managers. Cultural identity is a complex and multifaceted concept that includes **race and ethnicity**, **religious differences**, and **national origin**. By implementing strategies such as diversity training, appropriate responses to

complaints, and conflict resolution, managers can cultivate an environment where employees feel valued and respected, regardless of their background.

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